

- **Grow up.** Most insurers will give you a lower rate when you hit a certain age, but their policies vary. Some will simply award you a 5% to 10% discount on every birthday until age 28 as long as you maintain a good driving record. Others will knock 10% off your premiums at age 25 (for a single man) or 23 (for a single woman). Your birthday is a good time to make sure you're getting the best deal out there. Call your insurer with a reminder.
- **Get domestic.** Insurance companies also view married couples as safer than singles. Married men can usually expect to pay 5% to 10% lower rates than single guys; the discount for married women is usually around 15%. A growing number of companies are extending this break to same-sex couples as well.
- **See if you're entitled to a household, or "multicar," discount.** If you're married and you and your spouse both have cars, see if you can save money by getting auto coverage from the same company. Insurers often offer discounts of up to 20% if both of your cars are insured on the same policy or by the same company. If you live with your parents, you might be able to get a similar discount if your car is insured under your folks' policy.

BAD CREDIT BOOSTS YOUR INSURANCE BILLS

Insurers, like creditors, look at your credit history when calculating your home and auto premiums. People who are in poor financial shape are considered more of a risk, so the credit rating agency Fair Isaac Corp. (see Chapter 3) has created special insurance scores to help insurance companies assess applicants. These work a lot like general credit scores and take into account all the same factors your credit report does. At the time of this writing, there's no way for you to see your Fair Isaac insurance score.

To further complicate the situation, there are specialized firms out there that keep track of the claims you file on your house or car.